

Emergency Preparedness / Disaster Plan

Drills, Response Strategies, and All-Hazards Planning Regulation: 42 CFR §482.15

POLICY OVERVIEW

Hospitals must have a comprehensive Emergency Preparedness Program based on an all-hazards approach that addresses their specific geographic, demographic, and operational risks. The program must be tested regularly and updated based on lessons learned.

KEY REQUIREMENTS

1 Risk Assessment & Planning

An all-hazards risk assessment must be conducted to identify likely emergency events (natural disasters, mass casualty incidents, utility failures, cyber attacks, pandemics). The Emergency Operations Plan (EOP) must address each identified risk.

2 Communications Plan

An emergency communications plan must include: backup communications systems, procedures for notifying staff, contact information for external agencies, patient tracking systems, and methods for communicating with patients/families during emergencies.

3 Policies and Procedures

The EOP must include procedures for: evacuation, sheltering in place, staff roles and responsibilities, supply chain management during shortages, volunteer management, and continuity of essential services.

4 Training and Testing

The program must be tested twice annually: at least one full-scale exercise and one additional exercise (which may be tabletop). Exercises must involve community partners and external stakeholders when possible.

5 After-Action Review

Following each drill or actual emergency, an after-action review must be conducted, documented, and used to update the EOP. Lessons learned must be incorporated within 90 days of the exercise.

COMPLIANCE NOTES

Emergency Preparedness must be integrated across all hospital departments. Staff at all levels must know their roles in emergency response. The Emergency Coordinator must have appropriate authority and resources to implement the plan.

COMMON SURVEY CITATIONS

Cited under §482.15(a) – Risk assessment, §482.15(b) – Policies and procedures, §482.15(c) – Communications plan, and §482.15(d) – Training and testing.